POTUS

By Selina Fillinger

CHARACTERS: *Harriet (Chief of Staff), Jean (Press Secretary), Margaret (First Lady), Chris (a journalist), Dusty (POTUS' pregnant dalliance)*

SETTING: *The White House – Perhaps not the current administration, exactly, but broad strokes of past presidents combined with stress dreams of future ones. And if we're being honest, an amalgamation of them all . . .*

JEAN: **(Pg 1- 3)** He said the words, "My wife's a ****?" *(expletive should be mouthed or indicated with a broad gesture rather than spoken) (beat)*

HARRIET: He said, "Please excuse my wife's absence. She's having a *****-y morning."

JEAN: Publicly? Who exactly was there?

HARRIET: Washington Post, CNN, New York Times, BBC, and three Chinese diplomats. Everyone heard it, everyone got it, two people ***gasped***.

JEAN: Well, that's not so bad.

HARRIET: Wow.

JEAN: It's not! We can contain that. We all have ****-y mornings sometimes. My son has them every week.

HARRIET: Margaret wasn't absent, she was in the room.

JEAN: Why didn't he see her?

HARRIET: She was sitting.

JEAN: And therefore invisible?

HARRIET: He was standing, so the diplomats felt like it would be rude to sit, so they were all standing in front of her, blocking his view.

JEAN: He stood for the entirety of the meeting?

HARRIET: He can't sit right now because of (pause) the thing on his . . .

JEAN: The abscess on his – right. I thought they were removing it.

HARRIET: They couldn't because **(Pg 4-5)** he's booked, Jean! His friend Jerry, from college, said he had the same thing and he should just rub tea tree oil on it.

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JEAN: **(Pg 6)** I don't want to know! **(Pg 11)** I'm going into the press room right now and **(Pg 6)** I'm trying to figure out if my biggest problem today will be explaining why the President of the United States used the word ***** to describe his wife to three diplomats – OR if there is something MORE awful I need to know about.

HARRIET: **(Pg 11)** *(with a week cheer)* Go get 'em! Wooohhh!

JEAN: Oh, shut up . . .

INTRODUCTION

One four-letter word is about to rock 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue. When the President unwittingly spins a PR nightmare into a global crisis, the brilliant and beleaguered women he relies upon risk their sanity to keep the commander-in-chief out of trouble.

For any woman who's ever found herself the secondary character in a male farce . . . This is POTUS by Selina Fillinger

MARGARET: **(Pg 7)** *(seething)* I'm gonna punt that man's abscessed ass across the South Lawn and if you don't get out of my way I will shred you like the sad cardigan you are.

HARRIET: **(Pg 9-10)** *(blocking the door)* He didn't mean it. He's in a lot of pain and it's clouding his judgment.

MARGARET: Dammit, Harriet, you cannot prevent me from having a marital discussion with my husband!

HARRIET: I absolutely can, especially today, when he has a nuclear non-proliferation meeting, a gubernatorial candidate endorsement and an oozing pustule on his . . . I finally got him calmed down from your argument this morning

MARGARET: It wasn't an argument

HARRIET: When you told him to stop behaving like his father, grow a pair and have the procedure without anesthesia?

MARGARET: I had two natural births and one root canal with no drugs, he can certainly

HARRIET: **(Pg 57)** Wait! I can't hear the TV!

CHRIS FROM THE TV: . . . President reportedly stormed out of the nuclear non-proliferation discussions after a fiery exchange with the Prime Minister of Bahrain.

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HARRIET: No, no, no!

CHRIS FROM THE TV: Sources within the White House say the President refused to sit for the duration of the negotiations, which the Prime Minister and several other world leaders interpreted as, quote 'an aggressive power move.' The Prime Minister says there will be, quote, 'regretful consequences.'

******** FLOTUS interview with CHRIS*******

MARGARET: **(Pg 25-26)** Well there is no typical, Chris. My daily work is determined by the ever-shifting needs of my five non-profits, two children, and of course, one and only president. The truth is, even before I was First Lady, after graduating from Stanford and then Harvard, I managed to keep busy with my law firm, my talk show, my book, my other book, my gallery and Taekwondo.

CHRIS: *(joking)* Why aren't ***you*** president? *(they both laugh for a moment then fall into silence)*

******** In the Hallway*******

DUSTY: **(Pg 28)** *(flags down Jean who is in a rush)* Wait, hi, hi, I know you, you're on TV!

JEAN: Ask one of the other interns . . . I can't

DUSTY: Could you just point me towards the president? I'm Dusty. **(Pg 18)** I was told to be ***discreet***. I'm here about the position. *(she winks)*

JEAN: **(Pg 29)** You're meeting with Harriet? *(struggling to comprehend)* But you're here to see the president?

DUSTY: He sent a private jet! I'm only here until tomorrow night and then I'm flying back to the farm.

JEAN: Hang on. . . The farm?

DUSTY: In Iowa.

JEAN: *(with dawning horror)* And you're pregnant.

DUSTY: Eighteen weeks! Big as a bell pepper.

JEAN: **(Pg 30-31)** *(to herself)* What's happening – how is this happening!

DUSTY: The president and I are in love . . .

JEAN: LOWER your voice, oh my god. SHUT UP!

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DUSTY: **(Pg 37)** Ma'am, I'm going to need you to take a deep breath

JEAN: YOUR NAME IS AN ADJECTIVE: DON'T TELL ME WHAT TO DO!

HARRIET: **(Pg 34)** *(entering)* What the hell is going on here?

JEAN: **(Pg 38-39)** YOU are Chief of Staff. YOUR job is to contain situations. I'm the PRESS SECRETARY. MY job is to contain STORIES, and I can't contain stories if I don't KNOW the STIUATION, so perhaps you'd like to explain THIS SITUATION. *(she motions to Dusty's pregnant belly)*

(The door to the interview room opens and CHRIS and MARGARET enter the hallway- Chris immediately turns on her phone to record)

MARGARET: **(Pg 40)** *(regarding DUSTY)* What is this?

HARRIET: **(Pg 42)** No, no, no, no . . .

MARGARET: If you think you can show up here, unannounced and blackmail the president

DUSTY: What? No, POTUS invited me. I'm here to celebrate our little president-to-be.

CHRIS: **(Pg 14)** *(softly into her phone)* I don't need to stir shit up: we got a president throwing his feces at the wall.

JEAN: **(Pg 42-43)** Oh shit.

DUSTY: When I sent him a pic of the ultrasound he texted me that I should come in to celebrate.

HARRIET: Nope, that was me. POTUS is really busy, so you and I are just gonna have a quick little chat and

JEAN: *(whispers to Harriet)* Here . . . You're doing this IN the White House?

HARRIET: *(whispers to Jean)* Where else am I gonna do it? A back alley? You don't think that'd make her a bit suspicious? *(to Dusty)* Okay, honey, here's the thing: as much fun as I'm sure you and the president had together.

DUSTY: We're in love.

MARGARET: *(cackles bitterly)*

HARRIET: The thing is this pregnancy is not, um. Happening. **(Pg 44)** See, the way it works is we give you money and, in exchange, the pregnancy isn't – it it it goes away. We're talking about the President of the United States, right? The ***married*** president.

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MARGARET: *(cackles bitterly- to Harriet)* **(Pg 9)** Your loyalty to my husband is admirable. I hope you continue to feel fulfilled by your choice to trade youth and beauty for a life of service to him.

HARRIET: **(Pg 44)** *(ignoring Margaret)* Do you see how that could make from some icky headlines?

CHRIS: **(Pg 12)** *(into her phone)* What a time to be alive, isn't it! *(suddenly everyone notices Chris who has been recording everything with her phone - Pandemonium ensues – a wild and epic chase)*

MARGARET: **(Pg 45-47)** **GET HER!**

JEAN: I GOT HER PHONE!

HARRIET: DON'T LET HER LEAVE!

CHRIS: *(grabs a bust from a pedestal in the hallway and raises it over her head)* Give me my phone and get out of my way or I will break this into a million pieces

MARGARET: That is notable suffragist Alice Paul!

CHRIS: I will break her ugly face! . . . One . . . Two . . . Three

(she hurls the bust just as the office door opens. It sails through the doorway offstage. There is a thunk of the bust colliding with an unseen person's head and the thud of a body hitting the floor. Silence – The women are frozen in shock sharing through the open door at the body on the ground)

DUSTY: **(Pg 48)** YOU KILLED HIM. YOU AND YOUR MEAN FRIENDS KILLED MY LOVE!

CHRIS: I'm going to go away for life. They're going to send me to Guantanamo!

MARGARET: **(Pg 50)** Chris, stand up. Jean, go tell the secret service that the president is going to be a bit.

CHRIS: A bit? He's going to be more than a bit.

MARGARET: Oh, I'm sorry, do you have a better idea? Because I though your contribution ended at death by discus!

HARRIET: ***Now, Jean***, before we go down in history next to Booth and Oswald!

CHRIS: **(Pg 52)** This is a matter of national security! We need to notify the vice president right now.

MARGARET: That man is as useful in a crisis as a turnip.

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CHRIS: Someone else, then. We murdered the president.

JEAN: You mean YOU murdered the president.

CHRIS: Don't. You. Dare. If he was doing his job he would be across the White House right now making peace treaties! He should not be living in this house, he should not be running this nation and you know it! He's the pyromaniac, but you gave him tmatches. You figured he'd burn his fingers and learn his lesson – Well he didn't, and now the whole world is on fire! So we douse those flames, or we will burn in them together, but don't think for one second I am marching to that stake by myself!

DUSTY: *(inspired)* Why isn't SHE president?

JEAN: *(launches the plan)* **(Pg 58-59)** We can still contain this. Stay visible, don't talk to each other. Then tonight, right when he's supposed to be onstage for his speed, POTUS will be found with a suicide note in his hand. He was unwell. He can't be responsible for his words, or his actions, he can't be held to etiquette – ***he was sad***!

HARRIET: *(sobbing)* It's too much. I'm too tired

JEAN: This is what you do, Harry. You've done it for years. You clean up his messes, you make excuses, you do his job and then you wake up and do it all over again. But what if *this* is the last mess of his you ever have to clean?

******** Dream vision of Harriet, Jean and Margaret in control********

HARRIET: **(Pg 61)** *(on the phone)* What do you mean, "Why would Norway involve itself? Because that's what allies do. You back us and in exchange we give you things that Norway needs, like peanut butter and genetic diversity . . .

JEAN: *(addresses the press)* Do I seem worried? No, like I said, the talks did not stall, they just broke for lunch. No, Eric, don't speak until I call on you . . .

MARGARET: **(Pg 67)** *(addressing the press)* Which is why it is with great pride and joy that the president and I endorse Leslie Hopper as the next governor of . . .

******** Dream ends – back to reality********

JEAN: **(Pg 77)** We can't just leave the body . . . What if something happens to it?

HARRIET: What's he going to do – stand up and walk out? *(a long loud moan from the*

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president - the women scream)

MARGARET: **(Pg 84)** He's awake! *(long beat, then to audience)* We told him he took too many pain meds, backed out and hit his head. Idiot totally bought it.

HARRIET and JEAN: *****! *(beep can censor this expletive)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2023 National Qualifier
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NOTES FROM THE PLAYWRIGHT ON CASTING: ***Margaret and Chris are Black, Jean and Harriet can be played by actors of any ethnicity.*** *American power structures are rooted in and shaped by white supremacy. Racism permeates our institutions, compounding gender and class inequity everywhere, but especially in electoral politics. This play is a critique of complicity in white patriarchy; thus, the casting requirements speak to those dynamics and must be followed.*

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